



Cambridge (CIE) IGCSE English Literature



Your notes

A Midsummer Night's Dream

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Plot Summary

One of the most important things you can do in preparation for the exam is to know the plot of A Midsummer Night's Dream thoroughly. Once you know the play well, you should be comfortable and familiar enough with key events that you can then link to themes and Shakespeare's use of dramatic techniques. Having an in-depth knowledge and understanding of the text will help you to gain confidence when choosing the most relevant references to support your response.

Below you will find:

- [an overview of the play](#)
- [a scene-by-scene plot summary](#)

Overview

A Midsummer Night's Dream is a five-act comedy written by William Shakespeare in 1595–1596. The story is set in Athens and also takes place in a forest.

The play begins with the Duke of Athens, Theseus, who is discussing his future wedding with his fiancée, Hippolyta. He is interrupted by an angry nobleman, Egeus. He is outraged that his daughter, Hermia, refuses to marry Demetrius as she is in love with another man called Lysander. She is told that she must either marry her father's choice or face the consequences. Lysander and Hermia decide to **elope** that night and set out for the forest.

Hermia's friend Helena is in love with Demetrius but he does not reciprocate her feelings. Helena tells him that Hermia and Lysander plan to elope in the hope that this will make him fall in love with her. Demetrius sets off to the forest to stop the lovers and Helena follows.

Meanwhile, a group of tradesmen are planning to perform a play during the Duke's wedding and are rehearsing the play in the same forest.

In another location in the forest, Oberon, the fairy king, jealously argues with Titania, his queen, over a little boy that Titania has taken into her care. In his anger, he orders his servant Puck to find an enchanted flower and plans to squeeze the juice of the flower into Titania's eyes when she is sleeping so that she falls in love with the first thing she sees when she wakes up.

Oberon also witnesses Demetrius arguing with Helena and so orders Puck to use the magic plant on Demetrius's eyes to make him fall in love with Helena. However, Puck mistakenly puts the liquid on Lysander's eyes; he promptly rejects Hermia and falls madly in love with Helena. Puck also transforms Bottom's head into a donkey's and Titania wakes up and falls in love with him.

Confusion **ensues** as Lysander and Demetrius are both chasing Helena, who thinks they are **mocking** her. Hermia is hurt and confused and becomes angry at Helena.

Eventually, Oberon's anger **dissipates** and he lifts the enchantment and helps Puck fix his mistakes. After getting lost in the woods separately, the four young lovers fall asleep. Titania reconciles with Oberon. The Duke and Hippolyta are hunting in the woods and find the four

Athenians asleep. Upon waking, they do not remember very much of the night before but Lysander loves Hermia and Demetrius loves Helena. The Duke takes pity on them and agrees that they should all marry. Bottom and the Mechanicals perform their play in front of the Duke and the couples

The fairies visit the couples as they sleep and bless their unions. The play then ends with Puck, who asks the audience to think of the play as merely a dream and to applaud if they enjoyed the performance.



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Examiner Tips and Tricks

While it is important to know and understand the plot, it is just as important that you pay attention to the stage directions Shakespeare uses. These give extra information about the action and the characters, which will help you to develop your own insights and interpretations about the play.

Act-By-Act Plot Summary

Act I

- We are introduced to the Duke, Theseus and his betrothed, Hippolyta, who are preparing for their wedding in a few days
- Egeus, a nobleman, complains to the Duke about his daughter, Hermia, who refuses to marry Demetrius
- Hermia decides to elope with her love, Lysander, and they agree to meet at the forest
- Another character, Helena, is in love with Demetrius but he is pursuing Hermia
- Helena tells Demetrius that Hermia is planning to elope and he goes to the forest to find the couple; Helena follows him
- Meanwhile, a group of tradesmen are rehearsing for the play they will perform at the Duke's wedding

Act II

- In the forest, the fairy king argues with his queen Titania over a little Indian boy who Titania is caring for
- Angry, Oberon orders Puck to find a magical flower that makes a person fall in love with the first thing they see when they wake up
- Oberon places the juice from the flower on Titania's eyes while she sleeps in her bower
- Oberon witnesses Demetrius's anger towards Helena and decides to make him fall in love with her
- Puck obeys Oberon's orders but mistakes Lysander for Demetrius, accidentally putting the magical plant on his eyes as he sleeps



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- Lysander wakes up and falls in love with Helena, abandoning Hermia

Act III

- The group of actors are rehearsing and Puck transforms Nick Bottom's head into a donkey's head:
 - The other actors run away and Bottom chases them
- He ends up where Titania is sleeping and when she wakes, she falls in love with Bottom as a result of the enchanted flower
- Oberon realises that Puck has put the potion on the wrong man and makes Puck find Demetrius to put the potion on Demetrius's eyes
- Demetrius wakes up and falls in love with Helena but Helena thinks he is also making fun of her
- Hermia threatens Helena while Demetrius and Lysander agree to duel
- Oberon tells Puck to prevent the duel and to lift the spell on Lysander while he goes to help Titania
- Eventually, all four lovers tire and fall asleep
- Puck lifts the spell on Lysander so that he will wake up in love with Hermia again

Act IV

- Oberon removes the spell from Titania so that she is no longer in love with Bottom:
 - He asks Puck to transform Bottom's head back to normal so that, when he wakes, he can return to Athens with the other four lovers
- Morning arrives and the sleeping four are woken by Theseus and his group
- They do not remember anything of the previous night and Demetrius confesses his love for Helena
- The Duke overrides Egeus's wishes and announces that the couples may be with whoever they wish
- Bottom wakes up and thinks that he dreamt everything that happened to him during the night:
 - He does not tell anyone about what he experienced as he is too busy preparing for the performance

Act V

- Theseus and Hippolyta talk about what the four lovers, Demetrius, Helena, Lysander and Hermia, told them
- The four lovers enter and they all then watch the play performed by Bottom and his peers
- After the play, they all go to bed and Oberon and Titania enter and bless the couples

Epilogue

Puck addresses the audience and asks them to remember the play as a dream. He wishes the audience a good night and asks them to applaud.



Your notes



Understanding the text

All questions in the Cambridge International Examination IGCSE English Literature encourage you to make an informed personal response. It is not enough just to know the text you are being examined on really well; you also need to develop a sound understanding of the themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events in the play you have studied, as well as an understanding of the significance of a particular moment or scene in relation to the whole text.

You also need to demonstrate an awareness of the text as a piece of drama and show an appreciation of the play on stage. All of this will help you to develop a sustained, critical understanding of the text, which will allow you to demonstrate your individuality and insights.

Each of the sub-topics below will help you to develop a better understanding of the text:

- [Background information](#)
- [Dramatic context](#)
- [Key moments in context](#)



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In your exam, try to take a more exploratory and discussion-based approach to your reading of the play as the examiner will reward you highly for this. Try to express your own ideas and arrive at your own meanings and interpretations of the text. For instance, you could begin to show your own interpretations by using sentence starters such as: "Shakespeare may have used the character of the Duke to highlight ideas about..."

Background information

A knowledge of the historical and social context of the play can help you to develop an informed personal response. However, it is very important that you do not include lots of historical information about William Shakespeare and/or the time in which the play was written in your answer. Your response to the play should focus on the question and the key theme, or themes, that the question prompts you to explore.

- William Shakespeare was born in 1564 in Stratford-upon-Avon:
 - Shakespeare was a well-known dramatist in the Elizabethan and Jacobean era, sometimes called the English Renaissance
- A Midsummer Night's Dream was written during a time when Shakespeare was being more creative with his plays:
 - It is believed that the play was written for an aristocratic wedding where it was also performed and Queen Elizabeth I was in attendance



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- It is believed that the play was written in 1595 or 1596 at roughly the same time he wrote *Romeo and Juliet*
- Some critics believe that there are **parallels** between *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, a comedy, and *Romeo and Juliet*, a tragedy
- *A Midsummer Night's Dream* differs from many of Shakespeare's plays as it lacks one single written source:
 - Links have been made between the play and the story of Pyramus and Thisbe from Ovid's poem, *Metamorphoses*
 - Theseus and Hippolyta's wedding has parallels with *The Knight's Tale* from Chaucer's *The Canterbury Tales*
 - The theme of a daughter **defying** her father's to marry the man of her choice is a common motif in Roman comedies
- The play features a range of characters, with names drawn from Classical Greek, like Theseus, to traditional folklore names such as Puck

Dramatic context

The literary context of *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is that it is a Shakespearean comedy, with a range of genre conventions, some of which William Shakespeare may deliberately subvert or challenge. *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is a play designed to be watched by an audience, so this is the context in which we should read the stage directions and any other relevant information Shakespeare provides, in addition to the dialogue.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

It is important to show examiners that you have an awareness of the form of this text. *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is a play so show the examiner you know this. Using the term "audience" instead of "reader" or "playwright" instead of "writer" is an excellent way of showing the examiner that you know about form.

It is also important to add that commenting on stage directions is as valuable as analysing any other method the playwright uses. Indeed, it has the advantage of showing the examiner you are aware of Shakespeare's intentions (the overall message he is trying to convey), because all stage directions show his intentions for what should happen on stage.

Staging

- Shakespeare employs stage directions primarily to introduce new characters and set the scene for changing dynamics between characters and settings:
- A notable stage direction, "*Re-enter PUCK, and BOTTOM with an ass's head*", sets the stage for one of the key comedic elements, which is Bottom being transformed into an ass



- Stage directions to add to the dramatic irony and tension in the play, for example when the audience understands the possible consequences for Titania when: “Enter OBERON and squeezes the flower on TITANIA’s eyelids”
- Stage directions play a vital role in developing the comic elements of the play, such as character transformations
- There is also a play within a play, performed at the end by Bottom and his fellow actors, which includes stage direction
- However, it is worth noting that Shakespeare’s original stage directions are minimal:
 - This gives the director and actors freedom of interpretation and performance

Key moments in context

It is not enough to just analyse a passage or scene in isolation; you must also consider why a particular passage or scene is important to the text as a whole. What key themes or ideas does it represent? Does it foreshadow future events? Does it reveal more about a character’s motivations, thoughts or feelings, remind the audience of what has happened or anticipate what is to come?

Revise some of the key moments from the play and how they are relevant to the rest of the text:

Key moment:

Act 1, Scene 1

Lysander: “The course of true love never did run smooth”

Summary of key moment:

- Lysander tries to comfort Hermia after her father and the Duke told her that she must either marry Demetrius, her father’s choice, or face the consequences

Why this is important in relation to the play as a whole:

- This quote foreshadows the challenges and misunderstandings among characters that will unfold as the play progresses:
 - It sets the tone for the romantic complications that will be a central focus of the play’s plot
- While A Midsummer Night’s Dream is a romantic comedy with elements of fantasy, Lysander’s remark introduces a touch of **realism** by acknowledging the complexities of love:
 - The realism adds depth to the characters and their relationships, making them more relatable to the audience
- The quote recognises that different characters in the play will experience love in diverse ways and each of these experiences will have its own set of challenges

Key moment

Act 2, Scene 2

Robin: (*squeezes flower juice on LYSANDER'S eyelids*)

"Churl, upon thy eyes I throw

All the power this charm doth owe.

When thou wakest, let love forbid

Sleep his seat on thy eyelid.

So awake when I am gone,

For I must now to Oberon"

Summary of key moment:

- Puck, acting on Oberon's orders, places the juice of the enchanted flower on Lysander's eyelids, mistaking him for Demetrius
- Lysander wakes and falls in love with Helena

Why this is important in relation to the play as a whole:

- This quotation reveals a crucial point in the plot, the magical intervention of Puck:
 - It sets the stage for a shift in Lysander's affections and further complicates the love triangle involving Hermia, Lysander and Demetrius
- Lysander, upon waking, falls in love with Helena and rejects Hermia:
 - He then begins to chase and pursue Helena while Hermia chases Lysander
- The ensuing confusion among the lovers adds to the humour and **farcical** nature of the play:
 - This action begins a series of events that will lead to misunderstandings, conflicts, and eventual resolutions
- The love potion creates a chaotic and unpredictable element in the play:
 - The audience anticipates the consequences of this magical intervention, heightening the element of surprise and amusement

[Next topic](#)



Your notes



Themes

Exam responses that are led by themes, or the ideas that Shakespeare explores in A Midsummer Night's Dream, are more likely to achieve higher marks in the mark scheme. If you can revise the play thematically, and focus on responding to the key theme/s in the question being asked, you will be able to write with greater fluency and assurance about Shakespeare's celebrated comedy.

Below are some of the key themes that could be explored in A Midsummer Night's Dream:

- Love
- Dreams
- Order and disorder



Examiner Tips and Tricks

The theme the examiner wants you to focus on will be given to you in the question. It is therefore crucial that you base your answer on the focus of the question, rather than just writing about all of the themes in the play or what happens. You should instead focus on how Shakespeare presents the theme in focus, and why he does this. Consider how Shakespeare uses characters, plot, setting or stage directions to explore bigger ideas.

Love

Love is one of the main themes in A Midsummer Night's Dream and Shakespeare explores it through a range of characters. As the play is a Shakespearean comedy, love is presented as **whimsical** and humorous rather than serious and passionate.

Knowledge and evidence:

- Shakespeare explores the **multifaceted** nature of love:
 - Different characters experience love in various forms, such as romantic, **unrequited** and enchanted
- The play features different characters with different experiences of love:
 - Hermia and Lysander represent true love
 - Helena experiences the pain of unrequited love
 - Oberon and Titania's love is jealous and unstable
 - Several characters experience false love or a fleeting **infatuation** as a result of Oberon's magical intervention



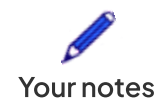
- Love is influenced by magic in the form of Oberon's love potion:
 - The potion causes humorous and chaotic situations, highlighting the unpredictable nature of love
- The play also challenges traditional norms of love and marriage:
 - Hermia and Lysander reject parental expectations to pursue their love
- The play features multiple layers of love stories, creating parallel narratives:
 - The **intertwining** plots emphasise the impact of love on different characters
- The characters experience sudden shifts in their feelings, which emphasise the **fickleness** of love:
 - Demetrius, for example, shifts from pursuing Hermia to falling in love with Helena
- Ultimately, the play resolves its central conflicts through the power of love:
 - The chaotic events have been fixed and the characters find happiness through love and marriage

What is Shakespeare's intention?

- Shakespeare uses the fairy world and Puck's mischief to portray love as unpredictable and chaotic:
 - The misapplied love potion creates confusion and highlights the irrational nature of love
- He infuses the theme of love with humour:
 - The comedic elements arise from the romantic conflicts and dialogue between the characters
- Shakespeare presents contrasting love stories to explore different layers of love:
 - He uses mismatched couples, fairy royalty and the Athenian court to showcase a variety of diverse relationships and their challenges
- The magical interference of the fairy world emphasises the transformative, otherworldly aspects of love:
 - Oberon and Puck's actions create an enchanted atmosphere that underscores the magic nature of love and romantic relationships
- Shakespeare also makes fun of societal expectations regarding love and marriage:
 - The play challenges conventional ideas about arranged marriages and the influence of social status on romantic relationships
- Shakespeare uses poetic and romantic language to convey the emotional depth of love:
 - The characters' speeches and **dialogue** are rich in metaphor and imagery, enhancing the presentation of love in the play

Dreams

Dreams are a key theme in A Midsummer Night's Dream and the idea of dreams is **prevalent** throughout the whole play, with many characters referencing dreams throughout the different acts.



Knowledge and evidence:

- The very title of the play suggests a dreamlike quality associated with the events that unfold:
 - The setting is midsummer, a time associated with magic and fairies, which contributes to the dream-like atmosphere
- The fairy world that Oberon, Titania and Puck live in adds a **fantastical** and dreamlike dimension to the play:
 - The interactions in the fairy realm are marked by magical elements, which enhances the dreamlike quality
- Puck's actions, such as applying the potion to the wrong character and transforming Bottom's head, contribute to the fantasy of the play
- The intertwining love stories are often described using dream imagery:
 - Characters reference dreams to explain the whimsical and irrational nature of love, highlighting the link between romantic emotions and the **surreal** quality of dreams
- Characters often use dreams as a form of escapism from their reality:
 - For example, Hermia dreams of a serpent eating her heart, reflecting her fear of Lysander leaving her

What is Shakespeare's intention?

- Shakespeare uses dreamlike imagery and poetic language throughout the play:
 - The use of metaphors, similes and vivid descriptions contributes to the dreamy atmosphere and enhances the overall sense of fantasy
- The play concludes with a reference to waking from a dream:
 - Puck's closing lines acknowledge the dreamlike quality of the events and suggest that the audience should consider the play as a fleeting, fantastical experience
- The play combines elements of reality and fantasy, creating a sense of magical realism:
 - The **coexistence** of the ordinary world and the enchanted forest blurs the boundaries between dreams and reality
- Shakespeare may have been trying to highlight the dreamlike quality of being in love, and the irrational behaviour of those who are in love is evident through the characters

Order and disorder

Shakespeare explores the theme of order and disorder in the play through various dramatic elements, characters and the **interplay** between the human and fairy worlds. Order and disorder can also be linked to the rational and irrational and the need for balance.

Knowledge and evidence:

- The play begins in the ordered, civilised, structured city of Athens:
 - The city is a reflection of societal norms and expectations, where people must follow the rules imposed upon them
 - The city contrasts the disorderly and magical forest
- The fairy world, ruled by Oberon and Titania, introduces an element of disorder and unpredictability:
 - Puck's involvement and the use of the love potion disrupt the natural order of events, leading to chaotic consequences
 - Puck's actions, such as transforming Bottom's head, also contribute to the disorder and confusion
- The play within the play, performed by the Mechanicals, is also marked by disorder and incompetence
- The conflict between Oberon and Titania over the small child disrupts the natural order in the fairy realm:
 - The power struggle between the fairy king and queen introduces disorder and conflict into their once harmonious relationship
- The use of magic **disrupts** the rational and logical order of human emotions:
 - Love becomes unpredictable and irrational
 - The potion creates a reversal of love and hate as Lysander's affections move from Hermia to Helena
- The resolution of the play involves the restoration of order:
 - The marriages of the four lovers and the **reconciliation** of Oberon and Titania signify a return to a harmonious state after the disorder and confusion
- The play concludes with references to the morning and waking from a dream:
 - This symbolises the return to reality and the restoration of order after the events of the night

What is Shakespeare's intention?

- The play explores the disruptive nature of love, as the romantic incidents challenge societal expectations and disrupt established norms:
 - The love triangles and misdirected affections create disorder among the characters
- Shakespeare may have used the contrasting settings to highlight the unpredictability of love and how it cannot be made to conform to societal expectations:
 - While the scenes in the forest are filled with confusion and disorder, it is ultimately a transformative setting, helping the characters to reach a happy resolution



Characters

Understanding that characters are often used symbolically to express ideas is critical to reading a Shakespearean play. William Shakespeare often used characters to represent or reflect ideas that were prevalent in Elizabethan society. Therefore, it is useful not only to learn about each character individually but also to consider them in comparison to other characters in the play.

When thinking about characters, try to consider the wide range of strategies used by Shakespeare to create and develop characters within A Midsummer Night's Dream. These include:

- How characters are established
- How characters are presented:
 - Physical appearance or suggestions about this
 - Their actions and motives
 - What they say and think
 - How they interact with others
 - What others say and think about them
- How far the characters conform to or subvert stereotypes
- Their relationships to other characters

Below you will find character profiles of:

Main characters

- [Hermia](#)
- [Lysander](#)
- [Helena](#)
- [Demetrius](#)
- [Puck](#)

Other characters

- [Theseus](#)
- [Oberon](#)
- [Titania](#)
- [Bottom](#)





Examiner Tips and Tricks

Demonstrate in your exam response that you understand how Shakespeare has deliberately created characters to perform certain dramatic functions within the play.

For example, try and think about why Shakespeare has chosen to present Bottom in the way that he does. Why was his head transformed into a donkey's head? What characteristics does he have that Shakespeare is perhaps mocking? Try and explore reasons as to why Shakespeare has chosen to do this and what it might suggest about the character.



Your notes

Hermia

- Hermia is a young woman from Athens
- She is the daughter of a **nobleman** named Egeus
- Hermia is in love with Lysander and refuses to marry her father's choice, Demetrius
- She is old friends with Helena:
 - She confides in Helena when she and Lysander decide to **elope**
- She is **defiant** and rebellious:
 - She resists her father's wishes for her to marry Demetrius because she does not love him
- From the beginning of the play, the audience sees Hermia's strong will and independence as she is determined to marry Lysander, despite the consequences:
 - She agrees to run away with Lysander to be with him
 - She openly speaks up in front of the Duke, declaring her love for Lysander
 - She threatens Helena and accuses her of stealing him
- She is self-conscious about her short height and displays some vulnerability when Lysander rejects her for Helena
- Hermia's **resilience** is evident as she faces various challenges including the effects of magical spells and related misunderstandings:
 - Throughout all of this, her determination to be with Lysander persists, showing her unwavering love and commitment
- She is a symbol of romantic rebellion, challenging social expectations and authority in the play

Lysander

- Lysander is one of the four central romantic characters in the play:
 - He is in love with Hermia and plays a key role in the romantic conflict involving Hermia, Helena and Demetrius



- Lysander goes against the wishes of Hermia's father, Egeus, by pursuing a relationship with her when her father wants her to marry Demetrius
- He is determined to marry Hermia and is willing to face the consequences of disobeying the law
- Lysander is portrayed as a charming and persuasive lover, using his speeches to win Hermia's affection:
 - He represents the **chivalric**, heroic **suitor** whose intentions are honourable and motivated by true love
- Like other characters in the play, Lysander falls victim to Oberon and Puck's magical interference:
 - He is accidentally enchanted and made to fall in love with Helena
- By the end of the play, the magical effects are reversed and Lysander is once again in love with Hermia

Lysander's **persistence** in pursuing Hermia against objections and barriers symbolises the theme of enduring love in the play

Helena

- Helena, another of the four Athenian lovers, is a friend of Hermia's and is in love with Demetrius:
 - It is implied that Helena and Demetrius were once involved but Demetrius abandoned Helena in favour of Hermia
- Demetrius does not return her love and this becomes the focus of Helena's story as she attempts to win his love
- Helena is characterised by a deep sense of **insecurity** and low self-esteem:
 - She believes herself to be unattractive and struggles with feelings of **inadequacy**, especially in comparison to Hermia
- Despite Demetrius's rejection, Helena remains persistent in her pursuit of him:
 - She follows him into the woods, even when it is clear that he does not love her
- Helena is willing to sacrifice her dignity and pride to win Demetrius's love:
 - She betrays her friend, Hermia, by revealing their plan to elope in the hope that Demetrius will be grateful and return her love
- Helena is also a victim of Oberon and Puck's magical interference, which leads her to believe that Hermia, Lysander and Demetrius are mocking her:
 - This adds a layer of sympathy to her character
- By the end of the play, Demetrius returns Helena's love and she achieves a resolution

Demetrius



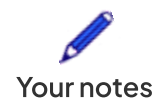
- Demetrius, a youthful suitor from Athens, seeks the hand of Hermia, with the support of her father, Egeus:
 - However, Hermia is not in love with him
- He is shown to be **fickle** as he was previously linked romantically with Helena before he agreed to marry Hermia:
 - Arguably, Demetrius is the opposite of Lysander as his love interests shift and he is not motivated by true love but driven by the laws of the land
- Demetrius rejects Helena, who is deeply in love with him:
 - Despite her persistence in pursuing him, he remains uninterested and is often cruel towards her
- Demetrius also becomes a victim of magical manipulation by Oberon and Puck:
 - Oberon orders Puck to use a love potion, causing him to fall in love with Helena
- Demetrius, under the spell, becomes a symbol of the irrational and unpredictable nature of love in the play
- When Demetrius falls in love with Helena, she does not believe him, which adds to the comedy
- By the end of the play, Demetrius and Helena become a couple

Puck

- Puck, also known as Robin Goodfellow, is a mischievous and playful fairy who serves Oberon, the fairy king:
 - His **antics** contribute to the comedic and magical elements of the play
- He carries out Oberon's commands, including the application of the love potion to various characters:
 - His actions serve as a catalyst for the romantic chaos that ensues in the forest
- Puck uses magic to manipulate the romantic relationships of the mortal characters, leading to humorous misunderstandings:
 - He mistakenly uses the love potion on Lysander rather than Demetrius, which results in confusion and chaos in the forest
- His actions and mistakes drive the plot forward, creating the tangled web of love and confusion that defines the play:
 - He deliberately turns Bottom's head into the head of a donkey
 - He accidentally applies the love potion on the wrong man initially
- Puck's magical spirit and mischievous nature contribute to the enchanted atmosphere of the play:
 - He is fun-loving but also capable of being cruel, which is evident when he transforms Bottom's head

- At the end of the play, Puck expresses remorse for his mistakes

Other characters



Theseus

- Theseus is the Duke of Athens, a figure of authority and leadership in the play:
 - He represents law and order in Athenian society
- He initially **upholds** Egeus's right to choose a husband for Hermia
- He is engaged to Hippolyta and plans to marry her in four days
- He is present at the start and at the end of the play:
 - He has no involvement in anything that happens in the forest
- While he initially supports Egeus's demands for Hermia to marry Demetrius, he later shows compassion and allows the lovers according to their own choices:
 - Theseus demonstrates wisdom and reason in his decisions

Oberon

- Oberon is the king of the fairies
- He is the mastermind behind the magical interventions that create chaos and confusion among the mortal characters in the play:
 - He uses Puck to apply a love potion on Demetrius and also Titania
- His relationship with Titania, the Queen of the fairies, is marked by conflict and jealousy over the possession of a young boy:
 - This conflict begins the chaos and confusion in the rest of the play
- Oberon plays a role in resolving conflict by ensuring that the lovers end up with their desired partners

Titania

- Titania is Queen of the Fairies
- She argues with Oberon, the King of the Fairies, over the possession of a young boy, which leads to tension and discord in the fairy world
- Titania displays a protective and **maternal** side in her concern for the wellbeing of the young boy and her interactions with her attendants
- She falls victim to Oberon's magic when he uses a love potion that makes her fall in love with Bottom
- Titania's **reconciliation** with Oberon and the resolution of their conflict contributes to the overall harmony at the end of the play
- She represents feminine power and strength, challenging traditional gender roles and emphasising the importance of balance between male and female characters

Bottom



Your notes

- Bottom is introduced as a weaver and a member of an **amateur** acting group who are preparing to perform a play at the Duke's wedding
- He is overconfident and **boastful** about his acting abilities, considering himself capable of performing every role; he provides comic relief in the play
- Bottom is the victim of Puck's mischief, resulting in his head being transformed into a donkey's:
 - His transformation symbolises his absurdity and comic foolishness
- His interactions with Titania, who falls in love with him due to magical interference, also contribute to the play's comedy



Writer's Methods and Techniques

"Writer's methods and techniques" is an umbrella term for anything the writer or playwright does on purpose to create meaning. Using the writer's name in your response will help you to think about the text as a conscious construct and will keep reminding you that William Shakespeare purposely put the text together.

The best responses at IGCSE don't limit their analysis to individual words and phrases. Examiners are really looking for analysis of Shakespeare's overall aims, so try to take a "whole-text" approach to his methods and techniques as a playwright. Below are some of the methods and techniques used in A Midsummer Night's Dream.

- [Form and structure](#)
- [Motifs and symbolism](#)



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In the exam, the question may involve the command word "how" and will refer to the author. This invites you to explore the craft of writing/the writer's methods and go beyond the "what" of the text to thinking about the text as a conscious construct, exploring what the writer has done deliberately to create meaning.

Form and structure

The form and structure of A Midsummer Night's Dream demonstrate William Shakespeare's mastery in crafting a multi-layered narrative. The play is a classic example of a Shakespearean comedy as it includes mishaps and confusion but, ultimately, has a romantic resolution.

- The play consists of three **interconnected** plots:
 - The romantic **escapades** of the young Athenians, the fairy world of Oberon and Titania and the amateur actors preparing and performing their play
 - These plots run **concurrently**, influencing one another, which adds depth to the narrative by exploring different **facets** of love and fantasy
- The play exhibits a symmetrical design with the events in Athens mirrored by those in the forest:
 - The romantic conflicts and resolutions in both settings echo each other
 - This symmetry emphasises the magical and transformative nature of the forest, where the characters' normal boundaries are disrupted



- Shakespeare uses verse and prose to reveal the status and relationships of his characters in their speeches:
 - He uses **rhymed verse** for the Athenian lovers when they are speaking of their love
 - He uses blank verse, or unrhymed **iambic pentameter** for noble characters, such as the Duke
 - He uses prose for lower status characters such as Bottom and the Mechanicals
 - It is worth noting that, when performing their play, the Mechanicals try to speak in rhymed verse to portray an elevated status but they do not succeed, adding to the comedic effect
 - This stylistic choice helps differentiate between the social classes
- The play has an **episodic** structure with distinct scenes, each contributing to the overall narrative but also capable of standing alone:
 - This episodic structure allows for the exploration of various comedic situations
- The play incorporates a play within a play framework:
 - The performance of the play by the Mechanicals, who are amateur actors, is a play embedded within a larger narrative
 - This structure serves both as a comedic **interlude** and a reflection on the themes of love and imagination

Motifs and symbolism

A motif is a recurring or repeated pattern that is a common literary device that helps establish a theme or mood, while a symbol might occur once to convey an idea or an emotion. Shakespeare uses a range of motifs and symbols in A Midsummer Night's Dream.

- A Midsummer Night's Dream is built upon the idea of contrast and it is a central motif:
 - Nearly every character in the play has an opposite, creating a pattern of doubles
 - For example, Lysander is a **chivalrous** gentleman whereas Demetrius is cruel and unkind to Helena
- The three main groups of characters, drawn from various sources like Greek mythology and folklore, are intended to contrast:
 - For example, the fairies are graceful while the craftsmen are clumsy
- The motif of love as a transformative force also runs throughout the play:
 - Characters undergo changes in their emotions and relationships under the influence of love
- The interplay between dreams and reality is also a recurring motif:
 - Characters experience dreams and visions, and the boundaries between the dream world and reality blur
 - This is especially evident during the magical night in the forest



Your notes

- The motif of nature is intertwined with the play's themes, especially in the forest setting:
 - The forest becomes a world where the characters confront their true selves
 - This motif emphasises the connection between human emotions and nature
 - Animals such as "wolf" or "wild beasts" are often referred to, symbolising untamed or wild feelings
- The moon is a recurring motif, representing magic, love and mystery:
 - References to the moon's influence on love, such as Oberon's spell being cast at night, contribute to the play's enchanting atmosphere
 - Nighttime settings enhance the dreamlike quality of the play
 - The play begins and ends with a reference to the moon, which emphasises the cyclical and timeless nature of love and the magical elements in the story
- Flowers are a recurring motif that symbolise love and enchantment:
 - The magical flower's juice, the use of flowers in the spell and the weaving of flowers into Bottom's hair are symbolic of love's influence



Key Quotations

The assessment objectives for the Cambridge International Examinations (CIE) IGCSE Literature in English state that you should demonstrate your knowledge of the content of the text by referring to the text in detail and using quotations from the text.

It is important to remember that you can evidence your knowledge of the text in these two equally valid ways: both through references to it and direct quotations from it.

Overall, you should aim to show a strong knowledge of the text, rather than just memorising and using quotations, as this will enable you to respond to the question effectively. It is the quality of your knowledge of the text that will enable you to select references effectively.

If you are going to revise quotations, the best way is to group them by character or theme. Below you will find definitions and analysis of the best quotations, arranged by the following themes:

- Love
- Dreams
- Order and disorder

Love

Love is a significant theme in A Midsummer Night's Dream and drives the actions of the characters in the play, especially the four Athenian lovers.

"Ay me! For aught that I could ever read,

Could ever hear by tale or history,

The course of true love never did run smooth ..."

– Lysander, Act 1, Scene 1

Meaning and context

- Lysander and Hermia have been informed by the Duke of Athens that they cannot marry:
 - Hermia's father, Egeus, **objects** to the marriage and wants his daughter to marry Demetrius
- The Duke tells Hermia that either she must marry Demetrius or she must face the consequences of her disobedience

Analysis

- Lysander's statement, now a famous proverb, is a reflection of the **inherent** challenges of love:
 - He expresses frustration and sorrow when he exclaims "Ay me!", hinting at the depth of his love for Hermia



- By using metaphoric language, when he compares love with the “course” of a running river, he suggests that love is often associated with obstacles and complications
 - The choice of the word “smooth” contrasts with the disruption to their relationship
 - By commenting on the universality of their experience, that love “never” runs smoothly in “tales or history”, he appeals to the compassion and empathy of the audience and other characters; the challenges of love are not unique
 - Lysander’s words foreshadow the complications and misunderstandings that will unfold in the play:
 - This prepares the audience for the twists in the romantic relationships of the central characters
 - Lysander’s acknowledgement of the challenges of love reveals his understanding of how complex love can be:
 - This sets him apart from other characters, who may have more naive views about love, such as Helena
 - This quote aligns with one of the play’s most important themes, which is the unpredictable nature of love:
 - It reinforces the idea that love is subject to external influences and internal conflicts
- “And yet, to say the truth, reason and love keep little company together nowadays” –**
Bottom, Act 3, Scene 1

Meaning and context

- Bottom’s head has been transformed into a donkey’s and Queen Titania has fallen in love with him, falling under the spell of Oberon’s potion
- Queen Titania declares her love for him and Bottom does not understand:
 - By stating that reason and love have little to do with each other, he implies that love can be illogical

Analysis

- By using personification, Bottom’s statement highlights a disconnect between reason and love in the play:
 - The phrase suggests that, in Bottom’s view, rational thinking and love have become **estranged** and are not often found together
- There is some irony to Bottom’s wise statement as he is not a character who is known for his intelligence, as he states later in the scene (and he is transformed into an ass)
- Bottom’s remark might reflect broader cultural attitudes during Shakespeare’s time:
 - It may be a commentary on the popular view that love is often irrational and uncontrollable
- The quote reflects the tension between reason and emotion, which is a theme that **resonates** throughout the play

“Jack shall have Jill,

Naught shall go ill

The man shall have his mare again,

and all shall be well”

– Puck, Act 3, Scene 2



Your notes

Meaning and context

- Puck says this after he places the potion on Lysander’s eyelids to lift the enchantment
- The four Athenian lovers have fallen asleep and Puck has been ordered to undo the enchantment so that Lysander is in love with Hermia again and Demetrius is in love with Helena

Analysis

- The use of rhyme contributes to a soothing and optimistic tone, which reinforces the idea of resolution and order being restored
- “Jack” and “Jill” **alludes** to the traditional nursery rhyme, which suggests a harmonious pairing, implying that love will find its way back to order:
 - The simplicity of the rhyme mirrors the idea that love and relationships have a predictable and comforting structure, much like nursery rhymes
- The assurance that “all shall be well” conveys the theme of the restoration of love, harmony and order:
 - It reflects the overall structure of the play, where the resolution of conflicts leads to a happy ending

Dreams

The idea of dreams is prominent throughout the play and its importance as a theme is underlined by its appearance in the title of the play itself. All the characters refer to their experiences in the forest as dreams to explain the illogical incidents that took place there.

“May all to Athens back again repair

And think no more of this night’s accidents

But as the fierce vexation of a dream”

– Oberon, Act 4, Scene 1

Meaning and context

- Oberon speaks to Puck and tells him to restore Bottom’s head so that all the Athenians can wake up in the morning and return to the city
- He states that they will wake and believe the previous night’s incidents were just a dream

Analysis

- The call for a return to the city represents a desire to restore order and **normality** after the chaotic events in the forest:



- Athens is symbolic as a place of reason, order and logic, which is contrasted with the unpredictability and chaos of the magical forest
- Oberon wants the Athenians to “think no more of the night’s accidents”, which suggests a desire to dismiss the fantastical and magical events that occurred in the forest:
 - The use of the word “accident” implies that the disruptions were unintended, reinforced by the choice of contrasting diction as Oberon wishes to “repair” his mistakes
- Oberon wants the characters to view the night’s events as “the fierce vexation of a dream”:
 - The comparison to a dream reinforces the theme of dreams and the blurred line between reality and fantasy in the play
 - It suggests that the magical occurrences should be regarded as fleeting and unreal
- The use of the phrase “fierce vexation” acknowledges the **tumultuous** and irrational nature of the night’s experiences:
 - It recognises that the events were emotionally charged and challenging but in the morning they can be viewed from a more **detached** point of view
- Oberon’s words also align with the broader theme of the play, which is the restoration of order and harmony after a period of chaos and confusion

“I have had a dream – past the wit of man to say what dream it was. Man is but an ass, if he go about to expound this dream” – Bottom, Act 4, Scene 1

Meaning and context

- This quote is spoken by Bottom after waking up the morning after his magical transformation
- Puck has restored his head and Bottom believes that everything he experienced the night before was a dream

Analysis

- Bottom has acknowledged that he has had a “most rare vision” or dream that is beyond human comprehension:
 - The famous phrase “past the wit of man” conveys the idea that the dream is so extraordinary that it cannot be properly described or explained
- The irony in Bottom’s statement is evident as he calls humans “an ass” if they try to explain the dream, having just been transformed into a creature with the head of an ass
- Bottom’s struggle to explain his dream underlines the limitations of language when trying to convey the magical elements of the play:
 - It could also highlight Shakespeare’s own challenges when conveying the extraordinary and magical through the medium of theatre
- Bottom’s experience and struggle to explain his experiences highlights the clash between the magical, irrational world of the forest and the rational, logical world of Athens:

- The inability to **articulate** the experience emphasises the dreamlike quality of the magical experiences in the play
- The frequent use of repetition of the word “dream” perhaps also serves to reinforce his dreamlike state



Your notes

Order and disorder

Order and disorder is an important theme and is evident through the juxtaposition of the two settings of the play: civilised Athens and the enchanted forest. Shakespeare also explores this theme through the disruptive presentation of love, finally resolved by the restoration of order at the end of the play.

“I am that merry wanderer of the night.

I jest to Oberon and make him smile

When I a fat and bean-fed horse beguile,

Neighing in likeness of a filly foal”

– Puck, Act 2, Scene 1

Meaning and context

- Puck introduces himself to a fairy
- He lists all of the mischievous things he does, including neighing like a young female horse to charm another, and reveals his role as a jester for Oberon

Analysis

- Puck introduces himself as the “merry wanderer of the night”, which establishes the character as a mischievous figure, who playfully “jests” with the king of the fairies
- This description of Puck’s antics is infused with humour but also gives the audience an insight into his character and his role in the play:
 - His character and actions contribute to the themes of disorder as he can “**beguile** others

“Lord, what fools these mortals be!” – Puck, Act 3, Scene 2

Meaning and context

- Puck is speaking to Oberon while watching the four confused Athenian lovers in the forest
- He is watching Lysander pursue Helena while Demetrius is sleeping
- Demetrius, enchanted by Oberon, wakes and also declares his love for Helena

Analysis

- Puck makes this remark after observing the confused and **irrational** behaviour of the human characters in the play:
 - The context is specifically related to the tangled romantic relationships and mistaken identities caused by the magical enchantments that Puck placed on the

male characters

- The term “fools” suggests that Puck is amused:
 - His perspective reflects the play’s broader theme that love often leads people to act in foolish ways
- Puck’s playful nature is evident in his enjoyment of the chaos he has caused
- The quote has an ironic undertone, as Puck himself has played a significant role in creating the confusion among the four lovers through his magical intervention
- This quote suggests that human behaviour in matters of the heart can appear foolish from an outsider’s perspective



Your notes